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Comps B

Company: Barclays

Job Profile: SDE

Offer Type: Placement Only

Internship Stipend: NA

CTC: 13.5

Location: Pune

Process Date: 26th and 29th of July

Placement Process:

There were a total of 3 rounds: OA, TECHNICAL-1, HR/TECHNO-HR

1. OA Round [135 Candidates Appeared]

The eligibility criteria mentioned was 7+ CGPA, but in reality, only those with 7.5+ were shortlisted.

The OA round [106 marks] had 3 sections:

Section 1: MCQs [46 Marks]

The MCQs were of medium to hard level, and covered topics like Java, OOP, SQL, a few pseudocodes, and C++/C snippets too.

Make sure you know **OOP, SQL, and Java** inside out if you want to crack Barclays.

Try to strengthen your core subjects in the **2nd year itself**, and practice MCQs in your 6th sem.

Section 2: Coding Question

The **coding question was the same as last year**, so there's a good chance they'll repeat it next year too.

Link to the question:

[Leetcode Discuss - String Generation OA Question](#)

The solution on Leetcode is very lengthy and not intuitive (uses DP + KMP).

Here's the **greedy solution** I used (passes all test cases):

```
class Solution {
```

```

public String generateString(String str1, String str2) {
    int n = str1.length(), m = str2.length();
    int sz = n + m - 1;
    char[] ans = new char[sz];
    boolean[] mod = new boolean[sz];
    java.util.Arrays.fill(mod, true);

    // 1. Satisfy all 'T' positions
    for (int i = 0; i < n; ++i) {
        if (str1.charAt(i) == 'T') {
            for (int j = 0; j < m; ++j) {
                int pos = i + j;
                if (ans[pos] != 0 && ans[pos] != str2.charAt(j)) return "";
                ans[pos] = str2.charAt(j);
                mod[pos] = false;
            }
        }
    }

    // 2. Fill unassigned positions with 'a'
    for (int i = 0; i < sz; ++i) {
        if (ans[i] == 0) ans[i] = 'a';
    }

    // 3. Enforce 'F' positions
    for (int i = 0; i < n; ++i) {
        if (str1.charAt(i) == 'F') {
            if (matches(ans, i, str2)) {
                int change = -1;
                for (int j = 0; j < m; ++j) {
                    int pos = i + j;
                    if (pos < sz && mod[pos]) change = pos;
                }
                if (change < 0) return "";
                ans[change] = 'b';
                mod[change] = false;
            }
        }
    }
}

```

```

    }

    return new String(ans);
}

private boolean matches(char[] ans, int i, String s2) {
    if (i + s2.length() > ans.length) return false;
    for (int j = 0; j < s2.length(); ++j) {
        if (ans[i + j] != s2.charAt(j)) return false;
    }
    return true;
}
}

```

If you want to practice or run your own approach, you can try it here:

[Lexicographically Smallest Generated String – Leetcode](#)

Section 3: SQL Query

I got a **very easy** SQL query based on basic filtering using **WHERE** and **AND**.

Some people got slightly trickier ones – for example, extracting a month from a date.

2. Technical Round [37 Candidates Appeared]

This round varied for everyone – some were asked core subject questions, some were asked about their resumes (VERY IMPORTANT: know your resume inside-out), and others were asked system design basics. Barclays focuses more on **"WHY"** than just **"HOW."**

For me, I was asked a **DSA question, a puzzle, a system design question, and a SQL query**.

- **Introduction:**

I introduced myself and mentioned that I enjoy solving DSA on Leetcode and building projects that solve real-world problems. (He wrote this down – probably why he asked me DSA and Design questions).

- **DSA Question:**

He asked me to help sort an array using **Merge Sort**. I explained the recursion tree, merging logic, why Merge Sort is better than other algorithms, and its time complexity. Then I wrote the code, explained it line by line, and did a dry run with 2-3 examples.

- **IDE & Debugging:**

He asked if I'd used IntelliJ. I said I used to but switched to VSCode since it's better for Dev too.

Then he asked how I debug code – I explained all my approaches: using the VSCode debugger, adding print statements, and dry-running edge cases.

- **Puzzle Question:**

Q: Cut a cake into 8 equal parts with 3 cuts.

Ans: Two vertical cuts through the center → 4 slices.

One horizontal cut across all → 8 slices. (Think 3D!)

- **Design Question:**

Design a Railway Management System.

At first, I misunderstood and started with schema design.

Then I asked for a hint – he asked questions like:

“How to assign platforms?”, “How to prevent collisions?”, etc.

I gave solutions for each.

- **SQL Query:**

Q: Return departments with more than 15 employees.

Ans: Simple `LEFT JOIN`, `GROUP BY`, and `HAVING COUNT(*) > 15`.

Tip from this round:

Try to **think in your head first**, **structure your answer**, and **then speak**. (I asked for feedback and this is what he told me LOL). But **never stay quiet for too long**. If you need time, **ask for a moment**, and **speak out your thoughts**. Start with what you know and go step-by-step toward optimization.

3. HR / Techno-HR Round [21 Candidates Appeared]

Some had a Techno-HR round, others had just HR.

For me, it was purely **HR**.

- Basic HR questions: Tell me about yourself, why Barclays, etc.
- A lot of behavioral questions – try to align your answers with **RISES values** of Barclays.

16 Students were offered the job, and 3 were waitlisted.

Useful Tips:

For Barclays: Have a **very strong grip on Core Java** – especially **OOP, multithreading, and exception handling**.

For any company: Maintain a **good balance between DSA and Development**.

I personally focused too much on DSA and too little on DEV.

Try to maintain a CGPA of 8+, I wasn't allowed to sit Zeta (which was giving a very decent package due to my GPA(7.97)).

Try to have **good projects** on your resume.

Projects deployed on the cloud or involving some system design give you a serious edge.
(Mine were quite basic, sadly.)

Placements is also about luck: I cleared MSCI's OA, and even after answering everything in Tech Round 2, wasn't shortlisted further.

Confidence is key: I didn't prepare for PhonePe's HR because I thought I'd be rejected after Tech, and I missed the chance